

NUCLEAR SHOWDOWN

With time running out for the deal, the Government makes a last-ditch effort to clinch it. But can the UPA do it without losing the Government?



IAEA chief Mohamed ElBaradei (left) with AEC chairman Anil Kakodkar



IAEA CLEARANCE: After five rounds of negotiations with the IAEA, negotiators appear confident of working an India specific safeguards agreement that takes into account most of Left's concerns

■ **By Raj Chengappa and Saurabh Shukla**

For the landmark Indo-US civilian nuclear deal, it is time for the big showdown. The clock on the deal is, as Richard Boucher, US assistant secretary of state put it, "now on overtime". Senators Joe Biden and John Kerry apart from Defence Secretary Robert Gates, who were in Delhi last month, emphasised the same message in all their meetings: This was India's Last Chance Saloon.

That urgency seemed to have provided a fresh lease of life to the deal, which was floundering after the Left parties threatened to withdraw support to the UPA Government if it went ahead with



The UPA-Left co-ordination committee members



UPA-LEFT COMMITTEE: The Left has to be persuaded to clear the IAEA agreement

it and BJP, the main opposition party, also opposing it. The first signal came when President Pratibha Patil in her address to Parliament mentioned that the Government was keen on getting the deal approved. Then External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee made a statement in Parliament significantly mentioning the nuclear deal as an endeavour that the Government was still seeking "a broad national consensus on".

Prime Minister Manmohan Singh in Parliament also seemed to indicate that the Government would make a last ditch effort to push the deal through. With UPA hoping that its populist Union